Chapter Thirty-Nine

The Fifth Crusade

Between 1217 and 1221, another crusade to Egypt fails

While the Albigensian Crusade was languishing towards its slow end in France, the Crusade authorized by the Fourth Lateran Council was limping towards Egypt.

The conquest of Egypt had been a Crusader goal for over half a century. Now governed by Saladin's brother al-Adil (who had ended the squabble between Saladin's sons by taking the Ayyubid throne himself), Egypt still controlled the city of Jerusalem. Al-Adil was seventy-two and in poor health, but still capable of mounting a sharp resistance.

"The army of the Lord assembled in great force at Acre," writes Roger of Wendover, "under the three kings of Jerusalem,* Hungary, and Cyprus. There were also present the dukes of Austria and Bohemia, with a large knightly array from the kingdom of Germany, and several counts and men of rank." Missing were all of the greater powers of Europe: the kings of England and France; the king of Germany and hopeful emperor, young Frederick II (although he had promised to arrive just as soon as his German crown was secure); any of the Spanish rulers.[1]

Andrew II of Hungary, the most powerful sovereign to take the cross, did so reluctantly, and only because he had promised twenty years to go on crusade and had still not fulfilled his vows. Nor did he stay long. He arrived at Acre in the late summer of 1217, realized that there weren't enough soldiers to do anything effective, made a couple of desultory raids into Muslim territories, and then declared his vow fulfilled and went home.